

Practice To Memorize Tunes While Expanding Aural Awareness

Step 1: Getting The Tune In Your Ear

Obtain several versions of the tune including at least one vocal version if applicable. The lyric will aid in quicker memorization of the melody, not to mention knowing what the song is about! Listen many times both actively and passively at points throughout the day. The melody and form can generally be learned from frequent exposure.

Step 2: Singing

Sing as much as the melody as you can away from your instrument and the recorded version. This is a good test to see how much has been internalized. If you're having trouble with this, go back and listen more.

Step 3: Play The Melody

On your instrument play the melody to the best of your memory. Once you've done this satisfactorily you can try adding harmony.

Step 4: Check Your Accuracy

Find the tune in a fakebook(s) and see how you did. Keep in mind that with standard tunes the rhythm will be written pretty squarely compared to a good recorded version. The fakebooks by Chuck Sher and Dick Hyman are very reliable sources with good harmonic changes. I also like the Hal Leonard Jazz Bible fakebooks from Ejazzlines.com. If you can't find a good chart you'll have to transcribe it for yourself, which is great to do as often as possible.

Step 5: Melodic/Harmonic Analysis

Understanding the underlying architecture of a great melody will make it easier to memorize and transpose. Relating melody and harmony is also essential for a complete understanding. Use roman numerals to identify chord function and find any modulations of key. Find essential guide tone lines in the harmony and melody if applicable. (see handout for example)

Find any guide tone lines available by tracing each note in a chord to its closest note or common tone in the next chord. A recommended book on voice-leading is Mick Goodrick's *Almanac of Voice-leading*. So far he has two volumes in the series.

Step 6: More Singing

Singing the root motion of the harmonic progression is invaluable. Then sing the arpeggios for each chord change, a great aid in hearing the changes. Next apply "moveable do" solfege to the melody. Finally sing stepwise guide-tones moving from chord to chord whenever the melody is resting. At this point the tune should be internalized enough to begin working on it further with an instrument.

Section 2: Guitar-Specific Ideas

Up The Neck

Take your best shot at playing the melody on only one string. It may be a challenge to find the string that the melody will sit easiest on. Octave adjustments are sometimes necessary and good to try.

Position Playing and Shifting Positions

Play the melody, in position (across the neck.) Play in different positions and shift into new positions where necessary. Work out logical position shifts considering factors such as timbre, slurring, ornaments etc. Ideally the melody should be practiced all over the neck and in all octaves.

Basic Solo Guitar

Devise a simple chord/melody that's easy to grab using "grips" or basic chord forms. The more creative stuff comes later. This really helps the ear and brain "marry" the melody and harmony.

Comping

Record a rhythm track of Freddie Greene style chords. Sing the melody over the backing track. Next sing the melody while you play the chords in real time. Then record a walking bassline and practice freely comping using 2,3 or 4 note chords with no low roots.

Melodic Embellishment

Start by playing the melody and where the melody rests, play fills that voice-lead smoothly back to the melody or a harmony note in the next chord. Keep getting back to the melody. Once you are comfortable with melodic embellishment improvise freely over the rhythm track.

The Melody Using Intervals

Adding a note a third or a sixth below a melody note is an important skill to master. Work out different ways harmonizing the melody in thirds and sixths making careful choices on which note fits the harmony the best. Most of the time one interval won't fit the complete harmony. Also try other intervals like tenths, fourths, sevenths, seconds, etc.

Bass/Melody

To be truly flexible in improvising solo guitar it helps to be able to play bass notes in half notes below the melody. Though it's possible to do this with a pick, greater independence is achieved by pick/fingers hybrid technique or ideally, a fingerstyle right hand technique. When you are first getting used to this contrapuntal style I recommend writing out portions of the tune emphasizing a syncopated melody.

Comping Below A Melody

Play the melody and where there is space comp chords to fill in. This practice keeps you involved with the harmony at many points along the way. To heighten your harmonic awareness at all times a simultaneous comping/melody approach should be practiced. Like the left hand of a pianist a steady 4/4 comp beneath the melody really adds another dimension to your music, think

Eroll Garner . Once you achieve some success with steady 4/4 it's time to begin freely comping below the melody. A great book for guitarists in this style is Lenny Breau's Fingerstyle Jazz by Mel Bay pub. These techniques may take years to get together so be patient!

Counter lines

While holding a melody note try to play a melodic line below it. This conversational style requires a lot of practice to ensure that the melody note is held out and that the answering phrase is a good one. An equally great technique is finding a guide tone line through the changes and playing it simultaneously under the melody line.

Melody Below Harmony

The melody becomes the bass line and the chords are played above it. Gene Bertoncini is great at this style of playing.

When you feel like you know the tune well in one key it's time to:

Transpose up a fourth or fifth, then any or all keys, reharmonize, play it in different "feels" such as swing, latin etc. Transcribe an arrangement, make up your own arrangement, compose a contrafact.